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Ray Brown

Bassist Ray Brown was born on October 13, 1926 in Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania. He entered the jazz scene in 1945 in New York City, and since then has played with virtually every major jazz artist, including Oscar Peterson, Dizzy Gillespie, Charlie Parker and Milt Jackson. Ray has performed in the recording studios of Los Angeles and with his own trio at jazz venues both here and abroad.

Ray was interviewed on audiotape in Scottsdale, Arizona on April 16, 2000, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: Well I thank you for sharing your time with me today, and I just had a conversation with someone who vouched for you as the greatest bass player in the world, Mr. Herb Ellis said that about you.

RB: Oh God. The oldest bass player, now that Milt Hinton has retired I'm the oldest.

MR: Okay you're the oldest. But it's documented on record that you're still playing great, and I want to congratulate you on your long career. I wanted to ask you just a bit about this particular thing that you had done fairly recently.

RB: Oh that's the "Super Bass."

MR: Yeah. Since I wasn't at this gig, was there three guys actually playing on this tune or was that just —

RB: Yeah, there's three guys, sure.

MR: That's great. Nicely done. I was looking at an old record from around the mid-1960s, with you and Cannonball and another couple of things with Milt Jackson, and in it you had said something about selling newspapers as a young boy and hearing music from the church and it made an impression on you. Can you tell me about how that felt back at that time?

RB: Well I grew up in a house where everybody went to church on Sunday. My mother cleaned house every Sunday morning. If you came in at eight ten, at eight thirty you left for church. Drunk, sober or whatever, you left. And it was a sort of high-falootin' for those days, black church and when the music started getting a little bit good if the people started moving a little bit they would say oh no, no, no, no, we don't want to sound like those heathens you know. And they would keep everything sort of imitating the white churches. So I'd be selling the newspapers and I'd go by these little — there'd be a little store that closed up and they got soap or something on the window so you can't see through. And there would be maybe twenty, twenty-five people in there and it'd be a piano and a couple of tambourines, and they would be stomping. I mean I could not leave. I'd just stand out there in the snow and listen. I mean the time and the feeling. I

mean you can't buy this. I mean anybody that wants to play jazz music should experience that. Because this is the essence, I mean all music has feeling to it. But I want to talk about jazz because it has something special you know. And it makes you feel good and it makes you move and it does a lot of things to you. And this is what the race was about. This is our contribution. This was it. There's something magnificent. And I didn't get that in our church.

MR: So you didn't mind selling newspapers in front of those churches then.

RB: Oh no I wasn't selling them in front of the churches. I had a fixed route. In other words I had customers. I mean I delivered papers to people. But these churches were on my route, there were a couple of them, and there were a couple of beer gardens where I'd stand out and listen to Jimmy Blanton play with Duke Ellington's orchestra through the glass also.

MR: That feeling of the church is not all that much removed from rhythm & blues is it?

RB: No. It's not that much removed from any jazz. Some of it was fast but it was just the groove that they had.

MR: You were nineteen when you went first to New York City about? Was it in 1945?

RB: I was eighteen, yeah, going on nineteen.

MR: Can you tell me about your first day there in New York City?

RB: Hell of a story. I'd like to have a dollar for every time I had to tell this story because I could go on a vacation for a long time.

MR: Really?

RB: I don't have to tell all the stuff leading up to it, just getting to New York.

MR: Sure.

RB: Okay. I arrived in New York after a day and a half train trip. And I had my luggage which was one suitcase, and my bass. I had been on a train. And I got off the train, I got on a subway, and I went up and got off at 168th and Amsterdam. And my mother's sister, my aunt, lived on Amsterdam and 166th. And I carried my bass and bag down the two blocks, and then she lived up on the — there was no elevator, it was a walk-up. She lived on the third floor. And I went up there and she had told my mother that if I came to New York I could stay with her until I got myself situated. And she had a son, same age as I, and she had a couple of kids. So I put my stuff in a room and then she gave me some dinner and I had dinner with my two cousins and my aunt. And while we were eating dinner I asked my cousin, I said, "Do you know where 52nd Street is?" He said, "Sure." I said, "Can we go down there after we eat?" He says, "Yeah, I'll take you down." So we finished eating and left, got on another subway and went downtown, got off. He took me around there and I looked in the first place, it was the Three Deuces. I don't remember who was playing in there at the time, I'm trying to think now but I'm not sure. I think it was Don Byas and Benny Harris. They had two groups in each club. And then the

headliners at the Downbeat, the next club, was Billie Holiday and Art Tatum. Not too shabby. And then the next club was Coleman Hawkins and he was playing with a rhythm section of Denzil Best, Al McKibbon and Thelonious Monk. And he only showed up on Saturday night and played "Body and Soul" and left again. But they had his name on there, and people would wait for him, you know they'd say, "Did he show up?" "No." And whenever his car drove up they would come out of all the clubs and rush over there just to hear him.

MR: Is that right?

RB: Yeah. And at intermission at that club it was a singer named Billy Daniels and the guy playing piano for him was a guy that I knew called Hank Jones, who is one of the premier pianists even right as I speak. And Hank and I had lived in the YMCA up in Buffalo years before, when I first left home, my first job. And so I said to my cousin, "Come on, let's go in there, I'm going to see if I can find Hank because I know him." And so I walked back and he was in the back and we talked for a few minutes and he said, "Sit down" and we sat at an empty table. And we're talking about what we had been doing since we hadn't seen each other and he looked up and he said, "Oh there's Dizzy Gillespie coming through the door." I said, "Wow" I said, "introduce me to him, I want to meet him." So Dizzy came in and he said, "Hey Diz," Diz walked over. He said, "I want you to meet a friend of mine." He said, "The kid's a bass player, just got in town." Dizzy looked at me and he said, "Yeah how are you" he said, "can you play?" And I said — you know what are you going to say when somebody asks you that? I looked at him — so Hank said, "Yeah he's a great player." So Dizzy said to me, "You want a job?" And I said, "Yeah." So he gave me a card out of his pocket and said, "Be at my house tomorrow at seven P.M." And I had already gotten a job, I had three job offers with three bands that I had sent away. I was in the south with a band called Snookum Russell, and they used to feature me all the time, because he and I used to do that Blanton-Ellington stuff, and we used to do that stuff that Slam and Lester Young did, because there was a guy that played like Lester Young in the band. And so they used to have flyers out, only in the south see, saying the Snookum Russell Orchestra featuring Ray Brown, world's greatest bass player. This was when I was eighteen years old, the biggest lie ever. But you know, nobody would know down in Mississippi so they didn't care. But I was trying to get out of the South and out of all of the stuff that was going on down there, I don't have to talk about. So I sent flyers to, I was reading a DownBeat magazine, and I sent flyers to two or three agencies and then I waited about three weeks and I called my mother and I said, "Did you hear from anybody?" She said, "Yeah, you got offers from Lucky Millinder's band, Andy Kirk's band and some other band. So she said, "Which one are you going to take?" I said, "I don't know I'll wait 'till I get to New York and find out." And so now

we go back up to where we were, and I go to Dizzy Gillespie's house the next day and there's four guys there. Dizzy Gillespie, Charlie Parker, Bud Powell and Max Roach. Charlie Parker I had seen with Jay McShann. Bud Powell I had seen with Cootie Williams' band. Max Roach I had seen in the theater with Benny Carter, and Dizzy I had seen with Cab. So I had seen all these people and I had heard them on record, but this was the first time. And then they started to play, it scared me to death. I mean I never heard anything like this before. But they played real fast. And that's something I could do. So I guess maybe that's why they kept me. But anyway he said, "Okay you'll do." We are going to work and he told me when. And I go back up to my aunt's the next day and I called my mother. She said, "Which one of the bands did you take?" I said, "Uh, I didn't take any of those?" She said, "Well what did you do?" I said, "I'm with Dizzy Gillespie." She said, "Who?"

MR: Those guys weren't all that much older than you, were they? Mid-twenties perhaps?

RB: But they were older than me in experience. That's what counts. Not how old you are. They had experience. All these guys had been through the big bands and now they were in small groups playing like man you just wouldn't believe how they played.

MR: Were you that familiar with bebop up to that point?

RB: No, the only bebop we had records of was Billy Eckstine when he was doing the big band stuff.

MR: Well you had a number of phases with Dizzy in the small group and the big band?

RB: Yeah.

MR: Featured you again, took advantage of your talents with "One Bass Hit" and all those tunes.

RB: Well you know I always say to people, I said first of all for Dizzy Gillespie to assemble a band like that, I mean you know the guy's got to have a lot of smarts to put a band together like that. And he picked up another guy two weeks later, Milt Jackson. So he knows what's going on. I mean everybody that he put in that band turned out to be some kind of monster on their instrument. So he had some knowledge. He could listen to somebody and say okay, come here.

MR: What was it like from a business sense and financially to try to keep a group like that together?

RB: Well I don't know what was going on in those days. First of all when you're eighteen and you get with a band like that, money has no part of that. All you want to do is get on the bandstand and play that music. Because if you've got enough money to eat — at times Jackson and I only had money just for dinner. So we would wait and go to a real nice place and have dinner and we would just starve the rest of the day, eat popcorn and a

Pepsi Cola or something so it would swell up. But money has no bearing when you're trying to play music, I mean when you're trying to get into music.

MR: And that concept I don't think has changed that much with young people.

RB: Well it should never change. I mean you can't — they don't go together. Although I think young people now are a little more money conscious. But when the money gets in front of what you're trying to do then you've got a problem.

MR: Norman Granz was a pretty important figure in jazz during those years. Was he a pretty upright guy to work for?

RB: Oh yeah. You know he did a lot of brilliant things. First of all he put jazz into the concert hall. He took it out of the dance hall and put it in the concert hall. He took it out of the night club and put it in the concert hall. He gave people the very best musicians, I mean he got the top people, he always had top people playing for him, and he paid top salaries. I mean he was a tough guy. I remember we would finish a tour and it would be, we'd go in the studio and it would be Coleman Hawkins, Lester Young, Ben Webster, Flip Phillips, Illinois Jacquet, Johnny Hodges, Charlie Parker, Dizzy and Roy and maybe Charlie Shavers and Oscar Peterson and Barney Kessell or Herb Ellis and myself and Buddy Rich or Louis Bellson. And he'd say, "What are you guys going to play?" And we'd figure it out, and he'd say, "Okay, one take." He says, "You guys are the best musicians in the world, I'm paying you the best money, one take. Play what you want to hear." Now if you tell that to some young musicians now — I tell guys that when I do clinics — they fall on the ground. I mean you read about this rock group just finished their album after a year and four months. I say oh man. Oh I'd like to have had a shot at something like that. I mean you could make a note every day. But things change.

MR: Make a note every day.

RB: Yeah. Or a bar.

MR: Plus you had, at those times, there was a time restriction on how long a tune could be also, wasn't there?

RB: No, it was the LP era, yeah, so we had some things that ran ten, fifteen minutes. But with all those guys playing it had to run ten, twelve minutes anyway.

MR: Yeah. Everybody's got to get their choruses in.

RB: Yeah.

MR: And there's the bass player. You guys never get to stop.

RB: Somebody finally figured that out, huh?

MR: I always felt sorry for the bass player, you know, everybody does their choruses and then you finally get to play one.

RB: I don't want any.

MR: The stint with Oscar. At that time in your career, musically, was that as about a high peak as you'd been to? I'm not sure I asked that question very well, but he must have challenged you and you challenged him and Herb and back and forth.

RB: Yeah. It was a good era for all of us because this, after all of us being with Jazz at the Philharmonic and now we wind up with that group, there's a lot of stuff that you have accrued over those years of playing with all those giants. And now all of this stuff can come out, and it comes out in various forms.

MR: The music was quite arranged in a lot of places.

RB: Yes. As a matter of fact I think that's part of — well people ask me, they said how come you have such an arranged group? I mean everything is laid out and picture perfect you know. I said probably because I jammed for twenty-five years every night. And you get tired of that too.

MR: I think it's refreshing, especially these days, to hear a group that's played together and rehearsed together. I mean jamming is fine too, but sometimes it's nice, I love the arranged part of jazz too.

RB: Oh yeah. Because you've got to remember the arrangement part of jazz is only in certain spots. There's a lot of freedom for guys to blow, everybody has got a lot of free space there. And I mean if you hear somebody play the same tune five nights in a row, the blowing's going to be different. The parts are the same, but the blowing's different. And if you get a jam session like one of these jam sessions here, if you've got the same group to play together for three weeks, five or six nights a week, they would start sounding like a band too. It would just happen like that.

MR: Yeah. You guys seem to have no lack of sense of humor in the Oscar Peterson Trio. Is that a fair statement?

RB: Well when we were young we did a lot of crazy things. I think everybody does. Nobody has a corner on that. If we all go back to when we were young, we carried on.

MR: I suppose you've read some of the anecdotes in the Bill Crow book.

RB: Yeah.

MR: Are they fairly true?

RB: Some of them are pretty close, yeah.

MR: There was one, something about Bill Harris who purposely knocked over something when Oscar was trying to sing or something like that?

RB: Yeah but that was the backlash of something that happened before. We were in Japan and we used to have something called a Ballad Medley. The Ballad Medley was everybody playing one chorus of whatever ballad he chose to play. So what they did is they would black out the stage, put a spotlight just in the front at the microphone. The first guy would walk out, he would walk past Oscar and he'd say "'I've Got It Bad' B flat" and then he'd

walk over. As he's walking to the mic Oscar would do a four or eight bar introduction. He'd play one chorus. And then as he's walking off to applause, the next guy walked by and Oscar would say so-and-so-and-so. And that's the Ballad Medley. Okay. Now all of these tricks and stuff are still going on. I used to lay my bass on the stage, because we'd have a break at intermission, and then we would start the second half with Ella Fitzgerald. So they would call Buddy Rich, Herb Ellis, Ray Brown, Oscar Peterson, and they'd say and Ella Fitzgerald. And she would come out and we would play as she was coming out. Well this night in Japan Oscar Peterson and Norman Granz got together and they went over and they tuned all my strings down see. Then when it's time to start, Norman Granz says, "Now ladies and gentlemen for the second set, Buddy Rich on drums, he goes out; Herb Ellis on guitar; Oscar Peterson on piano; Ray Brown on bass; and Ella Fitzgerald. Now so we practically came out at the same time. So these guys are starting when I got to my bass. And I pick it up and she's out there, and I go — and the strings are like limp. And she's trying to sing and I'm back there going [scats]. And she looks back — what? And I look at Oscar Peterson and he's got that look I know he's part of it see. Then I look in the wings and I see Norman Granz holding his side. They're just laughing away. Okay. So now in between shows I go out and I walk into some little Japanese joint down the street and there's something called Pachinko and it's little steel balls about this big, about the tip of your finger say, little round balls. And they go up in the machine and they come down in holes. So I played this thing for about fifteen minutes and I didn't win but there was a bunch of balls. And I put about thirty of them in my pocket. I go back to the theater. When they turned the lights out for the ballad medley, I reached in my pocket and I strung all these balls next to the hammers on the piano. So now the first guy to come out for the ballad medley is Bill Harris. And told Oscar so-and-so-and-so-and-so. And he goes to the mic and starts playing. Oscar hits the piano and it goes [scats] and it sounds like a calliope. So he's looking at me, what the hell? So that's how I got even with Oscar Peterson. So you see how those —

MR: So Oscar started it and the whole thing came in a big circle.

RB: Yeah.

MR: That's funny. When you moved to L.A., did you move here for the studio work?

RB: Absolutely.

MR: You did a lot of years of that. Was it everything that you had hoped it would be?

RB: Oh yeah it was great. Especially the first maybe ten years were just fantastic.

MR: Every day something different or did you get like maybe longer term contracts for T.V. shows and things?

RB: Well the most interesting work is the movies, because a guy writes a score for a movie, so even if you work for let's say Johnny Mandel on four different pictures, all the music

is different. But they were now in the throes of trying jazz composers, you know, people who were associated with jazz because they were getting more interesting music — music that — they were making deals, they started putting out albums. Sometimes the albums, the music would sell the picture. So they had people like Quincy Jones and Henry Mancini, Johnny Mandel, and Oliver Nelson and Michel LeGrand, a bunch of people associated with jazz music. And these people would hire orchestras but they had jazz musicians in these orchestras because they didn't have to write every note for them like they do for the other orchestras. They would just say play a solo here. And they would let you look at the scene and then you would play something to go with it. I mean many, many times I have worked, I used to work for Clint Eastwood, and he would have me come in after they finished, after we finished the orchestra and everything, and then he would play a scene and he would say, "I want something for that." And I would play something and he'd say, "Now let me see, give me something a little different." But they didn't have to write, you understand? The jazz musicians were able to create on the spot. So it was a great era for — I mean you had to be able to read music. You couldn't get away with that. But you had an edge in the fact that you could create stuff you know. I mean I worked with Lalo Schifrin. We did all of — that show that was so famous he did and I can't think of the name of it now.

MR: T.V.?

RB: Scats.

MR: Oh, "Mission Impossible."

RB: Yeah. And I used to get solos up the yinyang on that. If you listen to any of the old shows, I had tons of bass solos.

MR: All right, I'm going to listen for that.

RB: Yeah, all the time.

MR: Do you still get residuals from that kind of work? Was that in place at that time?

RB: We get minimal residuals. You get residuals for motion pictures mostly.

MR: How has the studio scene changed these days?

RB: You don't want to know. They're using machines now. I mean the music business goes through changes every — every ten, fifteen years there's a major change. I mean in places like Las Vegas they don't use live orchestras now. Everything is tape. I mean they just put the musicians away you know?

MR: I wonder if it will come in a circle and come back?

RB: You hope.

MR: Yeah, you hope.

RB: I don't think I'll live to see it, but some of the young people will.

MR: I remember some of the older players from way back talking about when the talkies came in that that whole orchestra was gone then, so I guess things don't change all that much.

RB: Yeah but let's go back before that though. I mean when they first made movies they had a piano player playing in the pit. Only one piano player. And it went from that to orchestras, where there was an era for thirty, forty years where every major studio in Hollywood had a hundred and ten piece orchestra, signed contracts by the year. They worked by the year. And they did all the music for all the pictures. But every studio had its own orchestra. And when I came to Hollywood they had maybe one orchestra left. And it was about to go out, because now the independents — in other words Henry Mancini or Quincy Jones says, "I don't want that orchestra," — he says I'll use some of 'em but I've got something else in mind.

MR: Yeah. I've got my own guys.

RB: Yeah. Because Quincy Jones did the unthinkable, he was the first guy to do this. He did a whole movie with no score. But he had all of his people in there. And it was successful.

MR: Yeah, you better have the right personnel if you're going to try to pull that off.

RB: Oh, well but it takes, it's an ingredient, you've got to have the right guy out front too. I mean there's a lot of things that go into that.

MR: Yeah. Actually you got into some managing at that time too?

RB: Oh yeah. Oh are we going to go into that?

MR: We could go by that, but whew. That's a tough business too, isn't it?

RB: It's all tough.

MR: When did this idea of having a piccolo bass come about for you?

RB: Me? No. I had no piccolo bass.

MR: No piccolo bass?

RB: The only guy I know played piccolo bass is Ron Carter.

MR: My mistake.

RB: That's okay. I had a cello that I messed around with.

MR: Oh that must be what I was thinking of.

RB: Yeah. That was just a lot of fun, we used to go and jam all day. We'd be in a theater and we'd play a show and then five bass players would come over and we would just go upstairs and jam until time for the next show.

MR: Out of the unbelievable list of people that you've played with, or that have played with you, is there anybody you felt like you missed along the way?

RB: I missed?

MR: Yeah. That you could have maybe enjoyed doing an album with?

RB: There are a couple of people I didn't record with but I played with them. I never recorded with Miles and I never recorded with Dexter Gordon. I never recorded with Eroll Garner.

I grew up with him. But I mean I played with him many times. I played with Miles, he played in Dizzy's big band. I played with Dexter but I didn't record. There's maybe a half a dozen people that I never recorded with, but just about everybody I've played with somewhere.

MR: I love these Cannonball records by the way.

RB: Oh yeah. He was such a marvelous player.

MR: Gee wasn't he great? And Ernie Wilkins arrangements were top.

RB: Yeah they were great man.

MR: What's the state of jazz in your estimation these days?

RB: I don't know if I'm equipped to answer that question. And I don't know who could really say all right I'll give you an answer. The state of jazz. What if I asked you to break that down?

MR: Sure. I mean when you look at the venues there are to play live jazz these days, does it seem healthy to you in comparison to different times in your career?

RB: Not that particular thing, no. I mean when I first came to New York in 1945 there must have been two hundred bars or clubs with live music. Every place had a live band. They weren't making much money but they were working. Now if you go to New York if you can find forty joints with live music you're doing good. But there were no jazz parties. There are jazz parties all over the place now. Something always replaces. We don't think about it, but something always replaces. There were no festivals when I was young. There was no such thing as a festival. We played theaters. Now there are no theaters but there's a lot of festivals. I mean you go to Europe, there must be fifty, sixty festivals every year. And there are festivals in this country. And festivals in Canada. And festivals in Japan. So something always — it moves around. They go to different venues. So when you say the state of the business, I don't think it really changes, it just changes shape. It's sort of like our bodies when you get older. You know, you get thick in the middle. It's still there. I weigh the same thing but it just moved around.

MR: It's recognized much more as an art form, which I guess is why we have all the concert hall concerts and the festivals. It's been put into schools, which I suppose is a good thing. Do you have any advice for young bassists coming up?

RB: Not that I could repeat.

MR: Well I know you've been very helpful to some young talent. I have it from a high source.

RB: Well I'm sort of like, I feel it's like going to see your kids do something. We've got three bass players besides myself here. Two of them were students of mine. So it gives you a sense of pride to see anybody that you've been associated with doing something and making something of themselves, and to get invited to this party to play you've got to be good. You can't be a non-player as we say. So I just like to tell [phone rings] — I'm not

here. I like to tell young people to study hard and practice hard while you're young. Because you get a lot done.

MR: I'm always I guess astounded by the number of tunes that you seem to have in your head — not you specifically but you included — at these kinds of parties. It just astounds me, I guess, the retention.

RB: Well yeah but that's how bass players make their living. I mean we're not front line, so you're supposed to know all of the songs. I mean it's just part of our business.

MR: Right. If anybody in the band is going to know it, it should be you.

RB: Well let's think about this for a minute. There's a singer up there and she says I want to sing some song. And she says one, two, three, four. We have to play the first note. The piano can wait and play the chord on the second or third beat. The drummer hits a cymbal. But the bass player has got to commit the first note. So really the thing is on us. We've got to know.

MR: A lot is on you.

RB: Yeah but I'm just saying, nobody thinks about that. But if you're a piano and you don't really know the tune too well, you can wait a minute.

MR: And make it sound like you waited on purpose.

RB: Well but I mean you don't have to play the first beat. But the bass player better play it or everybody's going to say — what? And they'll turn around and look.

MR: Any future projects in the air for you these days, besides you've got a great trio going.

RB: Well I've got a new trio and it's going to get better every day as we play. I've got something different I'm doing week after next as a matter of fact. I'm doing a weekend in my old home town, Pittsburgh, with the Pittsburgh ballet, my trio and Stanley Turrentine, the saxophone player. And Stanley and I have written the music for the ballet and they're going to dance to our music and we're going to play.

MR: Oh that's fantastic.

RB: So I'm kind of looking forward to that. I think that should be some fun.

MR: That's a marvelous event to have first of all to have live music with the ballet. Do you think you'll be recording this music?

RB: Well I think that they're going to be like some other people I know and tell me that it's for their archives.

MR: I see. And then they might have a couple of cameras, so you'd better watch out for that.

RB: Yeah.

MR: Well listen, I appreciate your taking your time with me today.

RB: Okay, yeah.

MR: And I wish you the best of luck.

RB; All right.

MR: I hope your ballet debut goes really well.

RB: Yeah I hope so too. I'm looking forward to it.